

Pikachu's space trip connects Pokémon with a science exhibition

From: DOGOnews Mined: 2026-10-03 5 min read

A Pikachu plush has returned from an adventure far beyond the Pokémon world. The European Space Agency, known as ESA, revealed on September 19, 2026, that the toy had spent 67 days aboard the International Space Station.

Pikachu launched on a Cygnus **cargo** spacecraft on April 11 and returned to Earth on a SpaceX Dragon **cargo** spacecraft on June 17. **Cargo** spacecraft carry supplies and other items. During its time in **orbit**, the plush completed about 1,040 journeys around Earth. An **orbit** is the path an object follows around another object in space.

The project was timed to help launch World Space Week 2026, which runs from October 4 to 10. ESA has created an **exhibition** that combines Pokémon characters with information about actual space **exploration**.

The displays introduce European space missions and life aboard the station. Visitors can also explore how ESA studies the Sun, the Solar System and the wider universe.

The **exhibition** tour began at ESA's headquarters in Paris, France, in late September. It is planned to travel to museums and other **venues** across Europe through April 2027.

There is also a Pokémon GO connection. From October 4, 2026, to April 30, 2027, players visiting participating European science and space museums will be able to join special game activities. These include One-Star Raids featuring Astronaut Pikachu, research tasks and opportunities to encounter event-themed Pokémon.

ESA hopes the project will spark curiosity about space and science among children and teenagers. Director General Josef Aschbacher said inspiring future **generations** is a key part of the agency's mission.

Word Treasure

cargo -- Supplies or other items transported by a vehicle.

orbit -- The path an object follows around another object in space.

exhibition -- A collection of displays that people can visit.

exploration -- Investigating places to learn more about them.

venues -- Places where events or activities happen.

generations -- Groups of people born and living around the same time.

Background you need

Cargo spacecraft transport supplies and other items.

An orbit is the path an object follows around another object in space.

The exhibition includes information about the Sun, the Solar System and the wider universe.

Break it down

The opening reports ESA's announcement about Pikachu's space station stay.

The next paragraph explains the journeys, orbital trips and meaning of orbit.

The article connects the project to World Space Week and describes the exhibition.

It then explains the European tour and museum-based Pokémon GO activities.

The ending presents ESA's educational hope and Josef Aschbacher's statement.

Why it matters

The exhibition uses Pokémon characters to introduce real space exploration. Its displays offer information about space missions and the universe, while ESA hopes the project will interest young people in science.

Test what you remember

1. What did ESA reveal on September 19, 2026?
 - (A) The plush had spent 67 days studying the Sun
 - (B) The plush had spent 67 days travelling to Mars
 - (C) The plush had spent 67 days on the Moon
 - (D) The plush had spent 67 days on the station
2. Which spacecraft carried Pikachu to the station?
 - (A) A SpaceX Dragon cargo spacecraft
 - (B) A spacecraft carrying museum visitors
 - (C) A spacecraft exploring the Solar System
 - (D) A Cygnus cargo spacecraft
3. What is an orbit, as explained in the article?
 - (A) A route visitors follow through a museum
 - (B) A plan for sending supplies into space
 - (C) A path one object follows around another
 - (D) A schedule for launching a cargo spacecraft
4. Where did the exhibition tour begin?
 - (A) At a space museum in Berlin
 - (B) At a science museum in Rome
 - (C) At a game exhibition in Madrid
 - (D) At ESA's headquarters in Paris
5. When are the special Pokémon GO activities available?
 - (A) September 4, 2026, to March 30, 2027
 - (B) December 4, 2026, to June 30, 2027
 - (C) November 4, 2026, to May 30, 2027
 - (D) October 4, 2026, to April 30, 2027
6. What did Josef Aschbacher describe as part of ESA's mission?
 - (A) Creating new Pokémon characters
 - (B) Organising museum game competitions
 - (C) Inspiring future generations
 - (D) Designing new plush toys

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: C 4: D 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **European Space Agency: ESA hopes the project will spark curiosity about space and science among children and teenagers.**
2. **Josef Aschbacher: He said inspiring future generations is a key part of ESA's mission.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):